

"There are reports that Rs 5,000 crore has been misused. The priests are robbing the money. *Ram naam japna, paraya maal apna* (chant the name of Ram and steal)"

—MALLIKARJUN KHARGE
President, Congress

raised by Santosh Dubey, an original *kar sevak* named in the Babri demolition case and now Dharam Sena chief, hint at a long history of foul play. Dubey claims that around 1,250 gold, silver, diamond-studded and *ashtadhatu* (a traditional alloy of eight metals, including gold and silver) bricks donated during the temple movement are unaccounted for.

The extension of the SIT's probe to July 15 and its decision to re-audit five years of accounts in their entirety, scrutinise every financial transaction, examine construction contracts and alleged commission payments, besides probing unaudited jewellery donations, indicates that investigators are looking for evidence of possible systemic financial irregularities rather than just individual wrongdoing. These development significantly raise the stakes for the investigation and suggest that the alleged theft may not have been an isolated act of embezzlement.

Rebuilding the Trust

What the controversy has done is put the focus on the original flaw in the Trust's structure: the concentration of authority in individuals. On paper, it appeared well-rounded—an assemblage of Hindu seers, a VHP-RSS core, four ex-officio government members. In practice, Rai, now 80, was a singular potentate for years. Anil Mishra also gained clout, strengthening the system of crony patronage. Speaking to INDIA TODAY, Mahant Dinendra Das, a trustee, called it "*ekchhatra raj*" (autocracy). He claimed he had been sidelined despite representing the Nirmohi Akhada, one of the original litigants in the Ayodhya case. "Ramji has saved my name from being tarnished," he added.

The alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya begs a larger question: how should India's richest and most-visited temples protect the wealth that flows in through faith? Answering it is important because there has been malfeasance in other big temples too. And, most often, these crimes are inside jobs, as in the alleged loot of gold at the Sabarimala temple in Kerala, where records were falsified and gold-plated artefacts were moved without proper authorisation.

India has no official count of Hindu temples, but estimates put the number at around 1 million, most of them small shrines maintained by local communities, hereditary priests or families. The challenge lies in the larger temples that own substantial land, jewellery and other assets, and receive heavy donations in cash, gold, silver and precious stones. Their management varies widely: some are family-run, some controlled by *mahant*s or *akhara*s, others by trusts, statutory boards or government-supervised bodies.

The Constitution permits state intervention in the secular aspects of religious institutions. Article 25 protects religious freedom, but Article 25(2) allows the state to regulate "economic, financial, political or other secular activity" linked to religious practice. This has enabled states to pass temple administration laws, from Tamil Nadu's Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments regime to Kerala's Devaswom Boards, Andhra Pradesh's 1987 law covering Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams and Uttar Pradesh's statutory board for Kashi Vishwanath after a major theft in 1983. But the line between regulation and control remains contentious. Uttarakhand's attempt five years ago to bring the Char Dham shrines under a state-supervised board triggered strong resistance from priests and stakeholders; the law was eventually withdrawn.

WHAT AYODHYA MUST DO DIFFERENTLY NOW

COMPREHENSIVE SOP: A standard operating procedure that clearly defines chain of command, responsibilities and effective monitoring mechanisms

WATCH THE MONEY: Strictly monitor financial transactions, ensure transparent data, maintain separate registers for cash and jewellery donations, make regular bank reconciliations, overseen by qualified accounting professionals

LEARN FROM TIRUPATI: Sealed *hundi*s, secure transfers to dedicated counting centres, CCTV-



PTI

▲ **HAND IN THE TILL** The temple embezzlement accused being produced in court in Ayodhya, June 26